US Rumble Strip Meta Doc

By drazi. on discord, dm for questions/concerns

1.1 The Spreadsheet/JSON/Map

This doc will summarize the most useful metas from my research, but if you want to go in depth per state you can check out this spreadsheet. I used this JSON to classify all of the locs I sampled for this research. A practice map for this doc can be found here.

1.2 Definitions

Q: What are rumble strips?

Rumble strips are grooves dug into the road at regular intervals, generally in the middle of the road or on the edges. Outer strips are on the edge of the road, and center strips are in the middle of the road. This doc covers rumble strip designs for **undivided** roads, meaning roads without a median. If you find mistakes in this doc, dm drazi. on discord.

Q: What kinds of strips are there?

There are 5 main types of rumble strips that I have classified:

Thin Strips:

Thin strips only refer to outer strips, also called thins or long thins. Thin strips are distinctly thin as shown to the right:

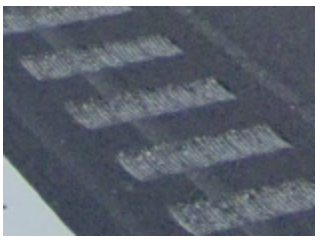


Small Thick Strips:

Small thick strips, commonly called smalls, can refer to either outer or center strips. These are strips which are thicker than the thins and are fairly short. Though this is an arbitrary category, it is useful.



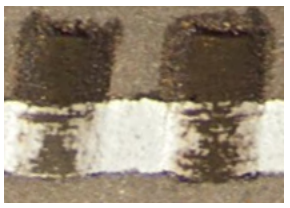
Long Thick Strips:



Long thick strips can refer to either outer or center strips. These are strips which are thicker than the thin strips, but are quite long, usually about twice as long as the small strip pictured above. The difference between long and small strips can be hard to see but can be learned.

Wiggly Lines:





Wiggly lines only refer to outer strips. These are (usually small) thick strips where at least part of the rumble strip overlaps with the line, resulting in a wiggly appearance. Note that the strip can be longer than the line and still be considered wiggly. Also, any use of small strips can produce wiggly lines for brief sections due to error in road construction.

Solid Strips:



Solid strips can refer to either outer or center strips. These are basically just one long rumble strip, though there can be differences between solid strip types.

Q: What are the thick center strip subtypes?

There are three subtypes of thick center strips: repeating thick strips, paired thick strips, and paired square strips. Repeating is where there is a constant distance between each strip, paired is where there is a distance between pairs of strips, and paired squares have pairs of small strips with a gap in the middle.

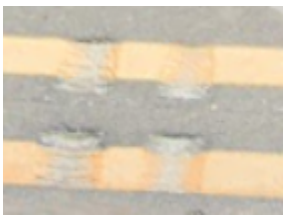
Repeating Thick Strips:



Paired Thick Strips:

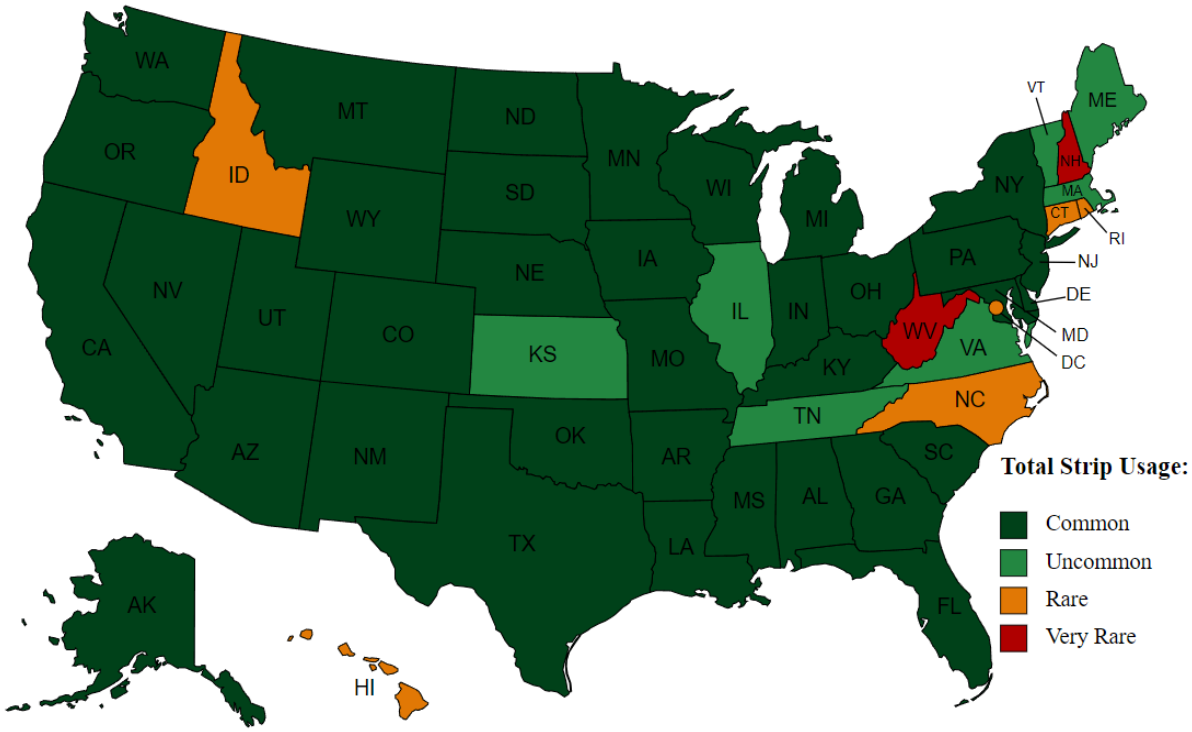


Paired Square Strips:

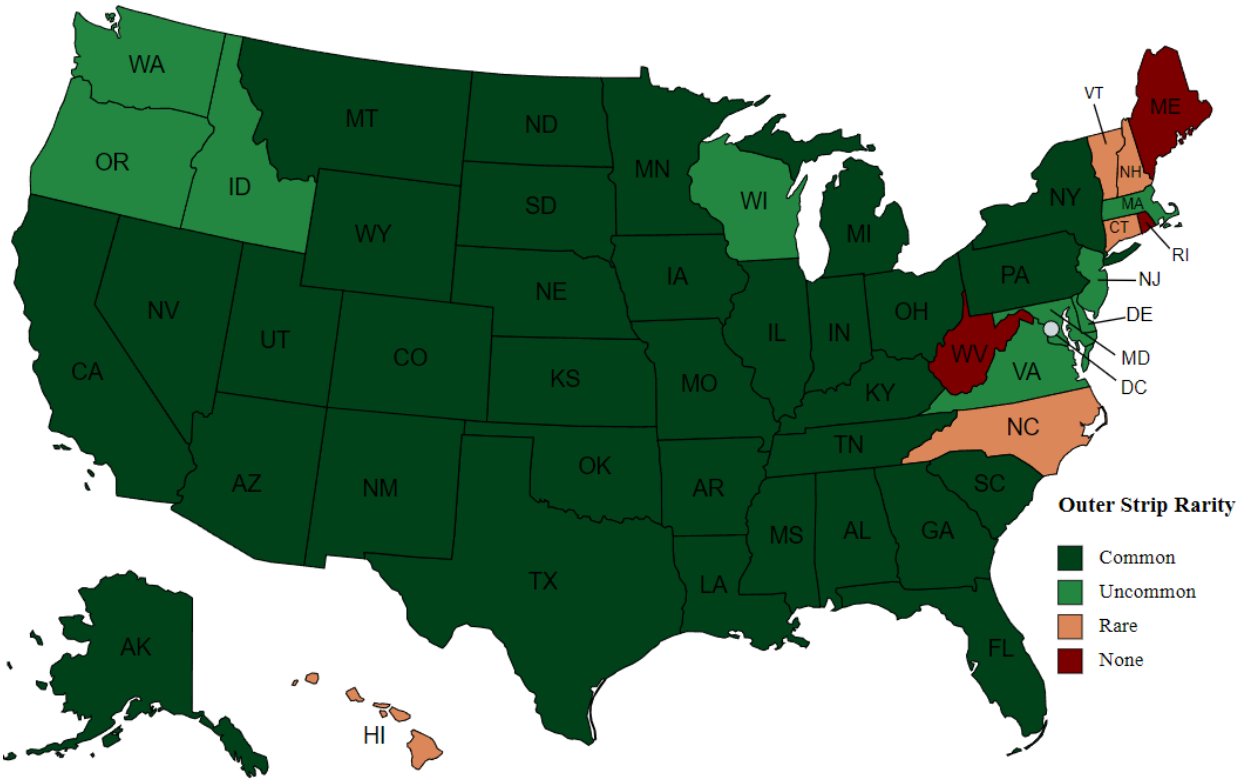


1.3 Rumble Strip Rarity by State:

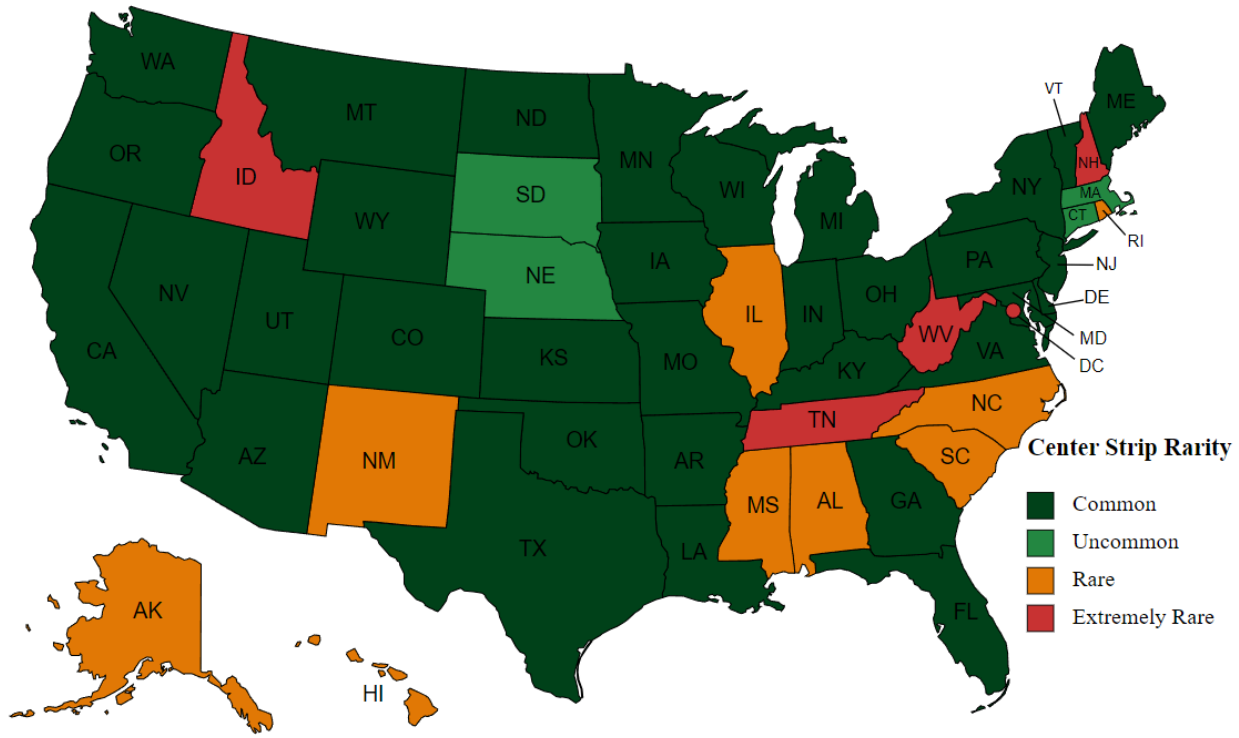
Total Strip Usage by state:



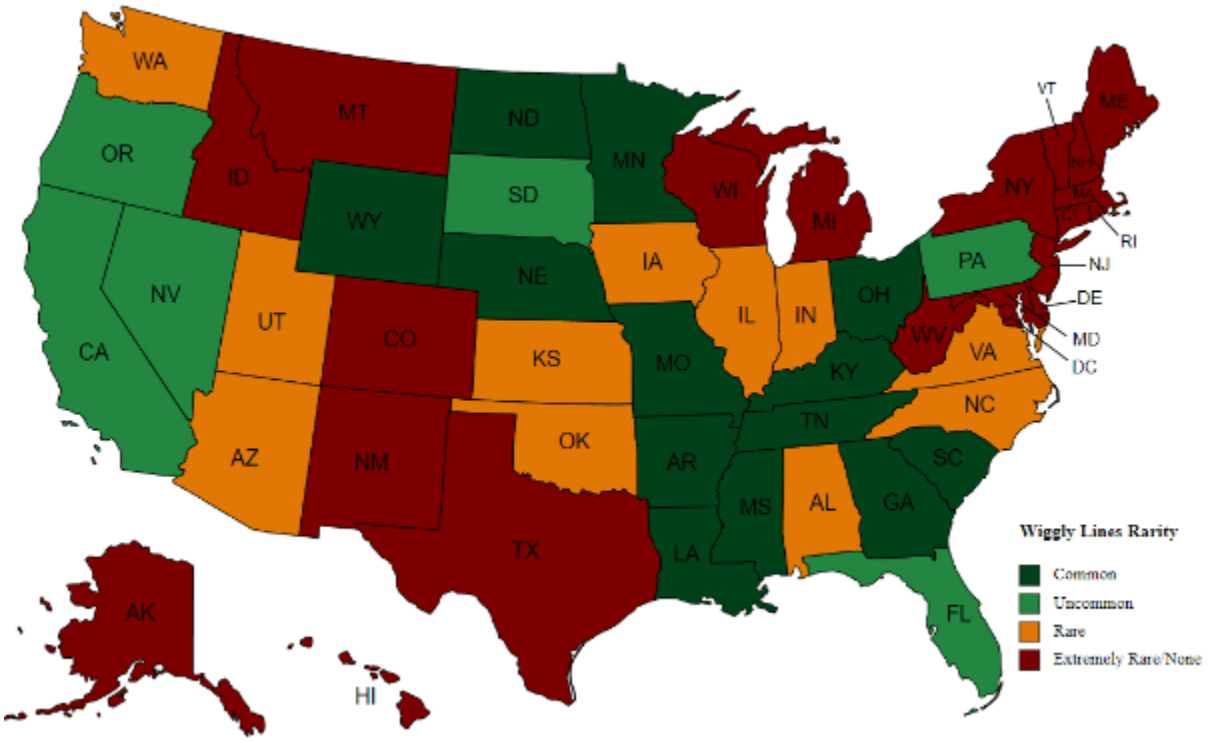
Outer strip usage by state:



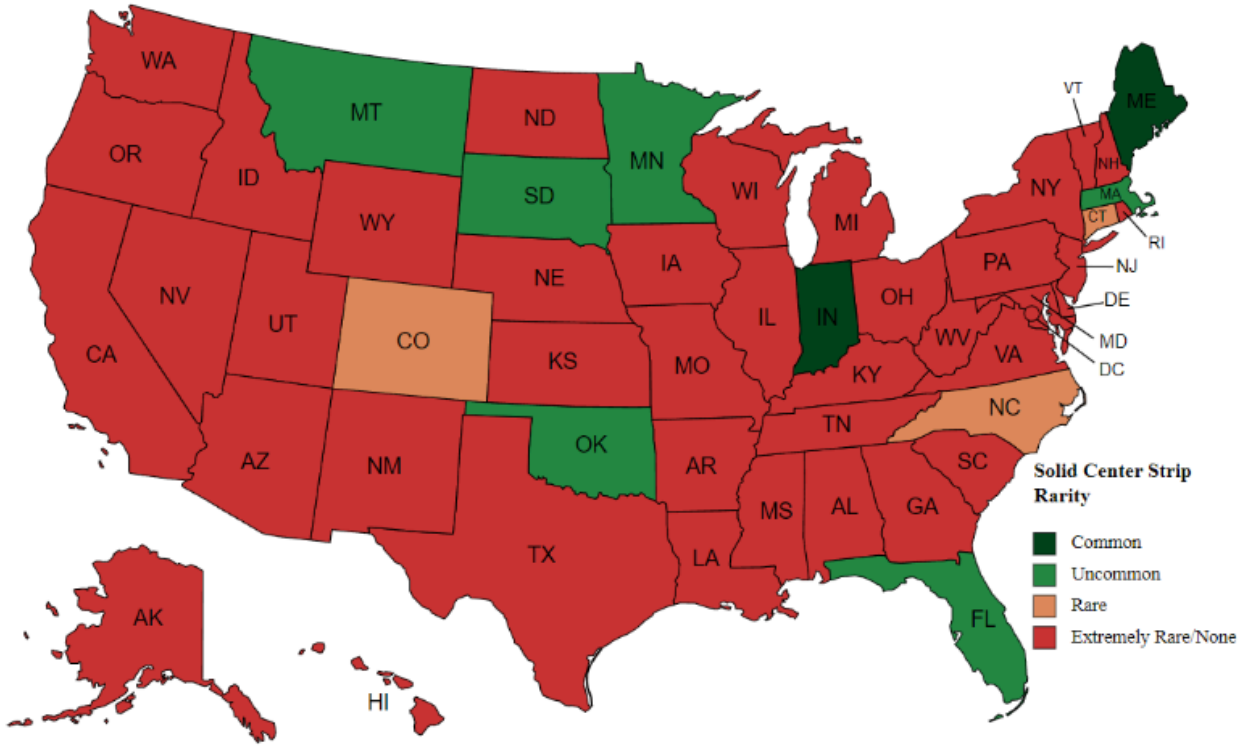
Center strip usage by state:



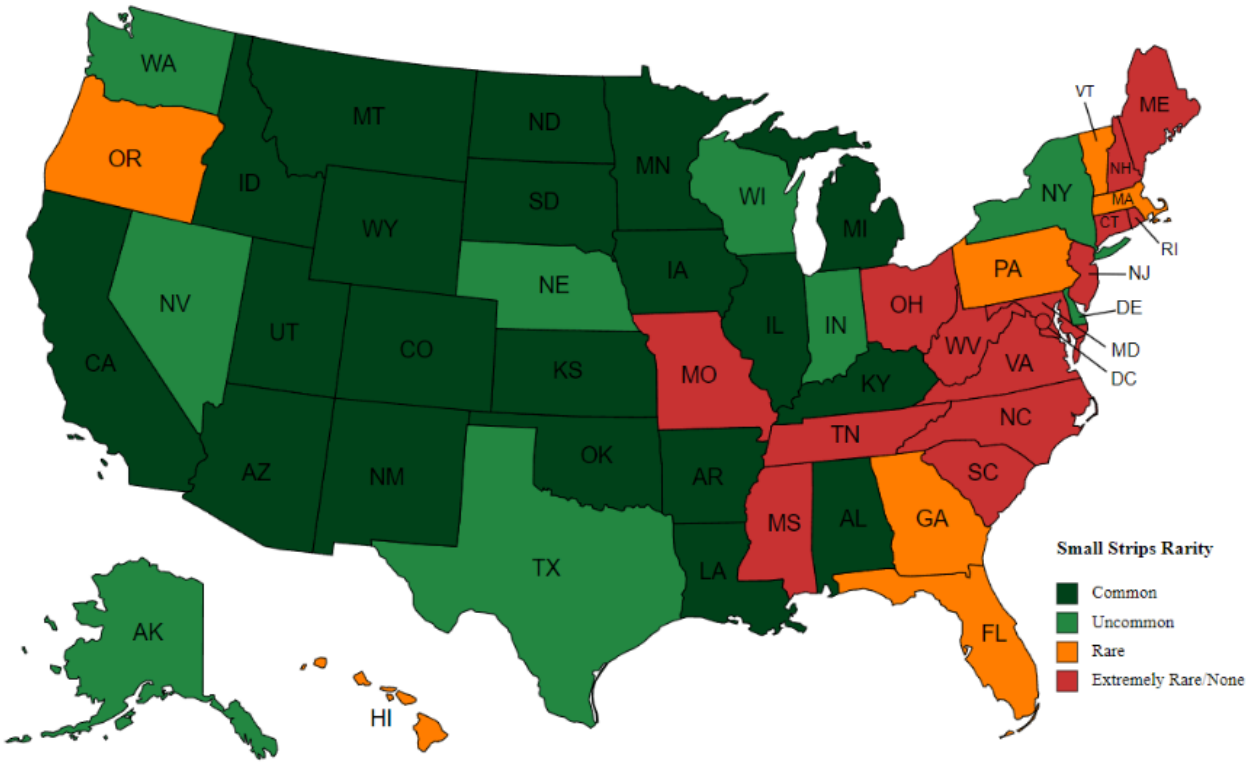
Wiggly Lines usage by state:



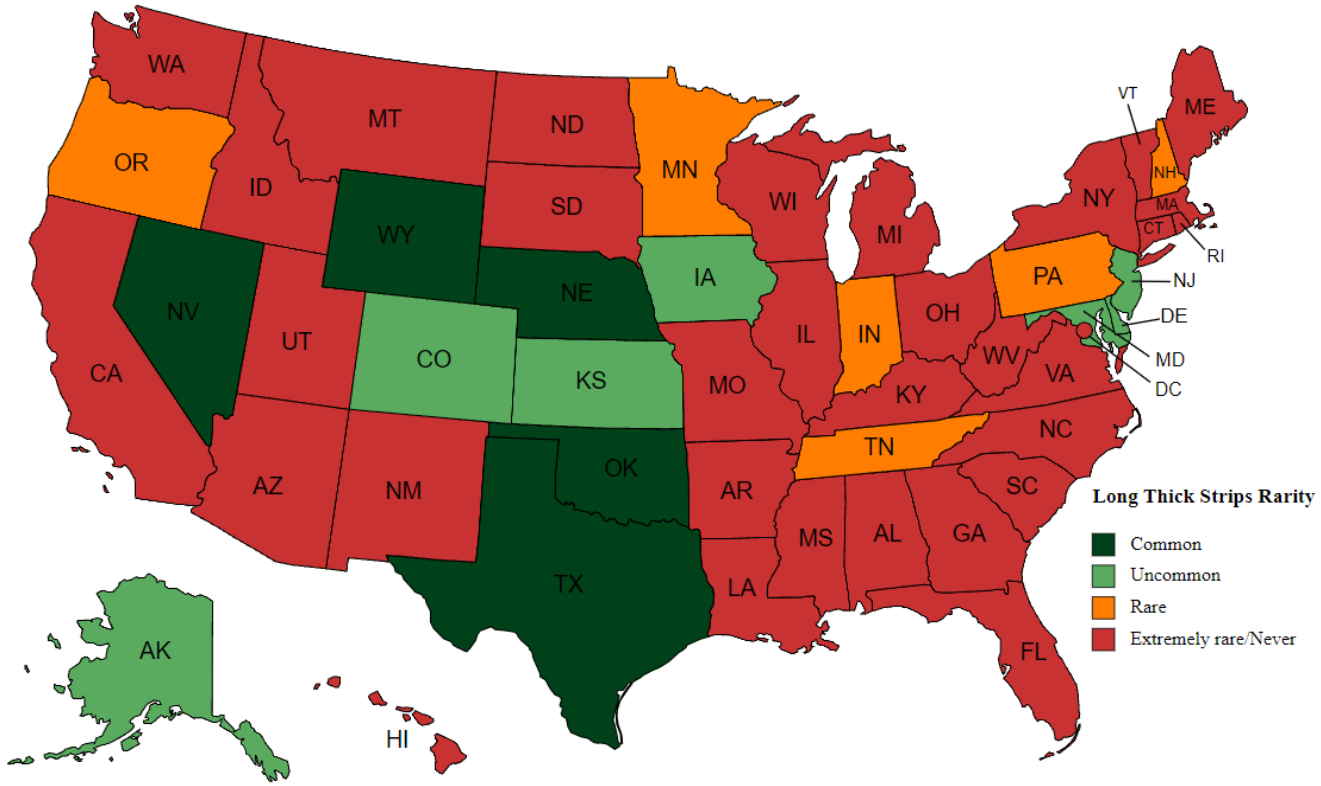
Solid Center Strip Rarity:



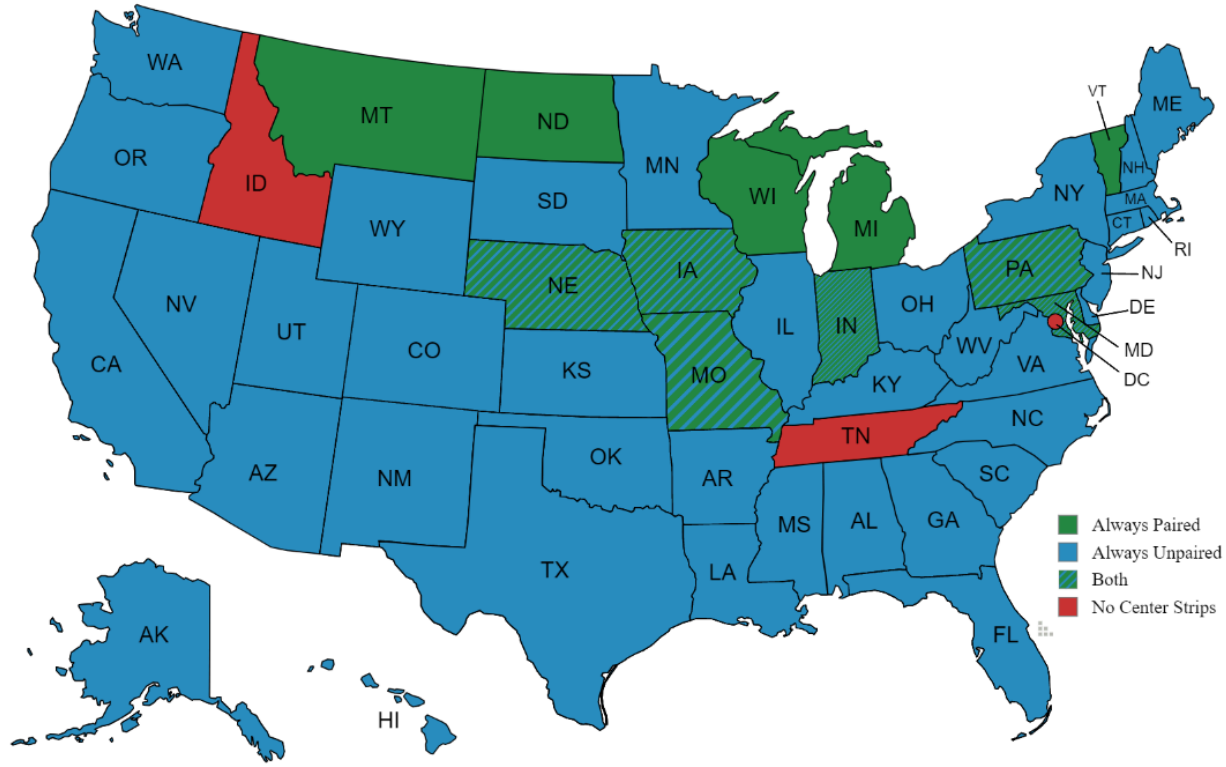
Small Outer Strip Rarity:



Long Thick Outer Strip Rarity:



Paired vs Unpaired Center Strips rarity:



1.4 State Specific Strips

Kentucky Strips:

Kentucky commonly uses thin strips on the edge of the road, which is unique to the state. These strips are not to be confused with long thin strips that do not reach the edge of the road, which can also be used in Kentucky but also elsewhere.

Kentucky Strip:



Kentucky Strip:



NOT Kentucky Strip:



Paired Square Strips:

On asphalt roads, paired square strips are unique to Nebraska, Iowa, and Minnesota. Nebraska exclusively uses these strips for center lines, but Iowa and Minnesota can use other strips. If the squares are repeating as seen to the right, it will most likely be Nebraska or Minnesota. If there are groups of 4 squares, it is most likely Iowa but can rarely be Nebraska.



Square strips can be rarely seen in Indiana and uncommonly in eastern Colorado.



Solid Outer/Center Strips

The two states you will see with solid center and solid outer strips on the same road will be Indiana and Florida, with extremely rare exceptions (like CO or WI). Solid outer strips without inner solid strips can be very rarely found in the upper peninsula of Michigan and Arkansas.



Raised circles/tabs on lines:

In Florida and Texas, raised circles or tabs can be found on either the center or outer lines in place of rumble strips. The circles tend to be larger in Texas, and the black center tabs are only found in Texas. The two left images are Florida, the other two are Texas. Raised tabs on the center line can be found extremely rarely in other states.






Mississippi Wiggly Lines

Mississippi has wiggly lines which are exclusively used in the state and which are unique within the southeastern United States (also seen in MO).



1.5 Common Tossups

Here are some commonly confused states with some ways to differentiate them, you can practice these on the rumble strip map here.

North vs South Dakota

	Unpaired Center Strips	Wiggly Lines	Center Strip
North Dakota	No	Common	Common
South Dakota	Yes	Uncommon	Rare

Iowa vs Minnesota

	Paired Center Strip	Solid Center Strip	Wiggly Lines
Iowa	Common	Never	Rare
Minnesota	Never	Uncommon	Common

Illinois vs Indiana

	Solid Strips	Center Strips	Small Outer Strip
Illinois	Never	Rare	Common
Indiana	Common	Common	Uncommon

Indiana vs Ohio vs Michigan

	Paired Center Strips	Solid Strip	Wiggly Lines	Small outer strip
Indiana	Never	Common	Rare	Uncommon
Ohio	Never	Never	Common	Never
Michigan	Common	Never	Never	Uncommon

Pennsylvania vs New York

	Paired Center Strips	Wiggly Lines	Small Outer Strips
Pennsylvania	Common	Uncommon	Rare
New York	Never	Never	Uncommon

Maine vs rest of New England (states east of NY)

	Outer Strips?	Solid Center Strip?
Maine	Never	Common
Rest of New England	Uncommon	Rare (uncommon in MA)

Nevada vs Utah

	Gaps in sets of center strips (see utah on spreadsheet)	Wiggly Lines	Small outer strips
Nevada	Very Rare	Uncommon	Uncommon
Utah	Common	Rare	Common

Wisconsin vs Michigan

	Thick Center Strips Length	Total Outer Strip Rarity	Solid Outer Strip
Wisconsin	Short	Uncommon	Very Rare
Michigan	Long	Common	Rare

Pennsylvania vs Maryland

	Paired Strips	Wiggly Lines	Repeating Thick Strip Length (see sheet)
Pennsylvania	Uncommon	Uncommon	Short
Maryland	Common	Never	Long

Arizona vs New Mexico

	Total Center Strips	Long Thin Strips	Wiggly Lines
Arizona	Common	Rare	Rare
New Mexico	Rare	Uncommon	Never

Texas vs Oklahoma

	Wiggly Lines	Solid Center Strip	Small Outer Strips
Texas	Never	Uncommon	Common
Oklahoma	Rare	Never	Uncommon

Kansas vs Nebraska

	Center Strips	Wiggly Lines	Small Outer Strips
Kansas	Long Thicks	Rare	Common
Nebraska	Split Squares	Common	Uncommon

Kentucky vs Tennessee

	KY Thin Strips	Center Strips	Small Outer Strips
Kentucky	Common	Common	Common
Tennessee	Never	Never	Never

Mississippi vs Arkansas/Louisiana

	MS Wiggly Lines	Center Strips	Small Outer Strips
Mississippi	Common	Rare	Never
Arkansas/Louisiana	Extremely rarely (near MS border)	Common	Common

Mississippi vs Alabama

	Wide Lines	Wiggly Lines	Small Outer Strips
Mississippi	Common	Common	Never
Alabama	Very Rare	Rare	Common

Texas vs Arkansas/Louisiana

	Wiggly Lines	Small Outer Strips	Paired RPMs on multilane roads (see rpm doc)
Texas	Never	Uncommon	Common
Arkansas/Louisiana	Common	Common	Never